

Assignment 2: Total Comp Reality Check

Pick one job you'd genuinely consider after graduation. Research it like you're preparing to negotiate the offer. Then answer the prompts below.

Your Information

Name	Target Job Title	Target City / Region
Carter Ward	Software Engineer	Auburn, AL

Source: [UDA Careers — Software Engineer](#)

Where to Research

Salary: Glassdoor · LinkedIn Salary · Levels.fyi (for tech roles) · Bureau of Labor Statistics

Benefits: Company careers page · Glassdoor reviews · "Benefits" tab on job postings

401k match: Often listed in job descriptions or Glassdoor Q&A. If not, it's fair to ask a recruiter.

Part 1 — The Comp Breakdown

Research the role and complete both columns. Use ranges where you can't find exact numbers.

Comp Element	What You Found (source in parentheses)	Your Reaction / What This Means to You
Base Salary	\$65,000 to \$85,000 per year starting range, commensurate with experience and qualifications.	Expected, seems like a normal base range.
Annual Bonus / Variable Pay	Bonuses mentioned as part of the total package, alongside profit sharing, but no specific percentage or structure is listed.	Yes, since no percentage is listed, this is a gap worth clarifying before accepting; a vague bonus promise is harder to value than a guaranteed number.
Health Insurance Type	BlueCross BlueShield health and dental coverage, no plan type such as HMO or PPO specified.	Yes, this matters; an HMO usually means lower premiums but a limited network, while a PPO gives more flexibility to choose doctors. This is worth
401k Match	401K retirement plan is offered, no specific match percentage listed.	Unknown from the posting, this is the single most important number to ask a recruiter about, since even a 3 to 4 percent match adds real value to total
PTO / Leave	2 weeks paid vacation plus major holidays, sick leave also referenced in the summary benefits line.	2 weeks feels on the lower end compared to some Alabama tech employers who advertise generous PTO accrual plus 10 or more paid holidays; this is
Remote / Hybrid	Onsite position based in the Auburn, Alabama office, no remote or hybrid option mentioned.	I need to be on-site, so I will have to move before starting the position.

Perks / Other	<i>Flex time for personal projects on company time, profit sharing, discounted health club membership, and stated opportunities for career advancement</i>	<i>Flex time for personal projects and the discounted health club membership seem useful; profit sharing is a nice bonus if the company performs well</i>
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Part 2 — Your Negotiation Plan

Based on your research, answer all three prompts below in 2–4 sentences each.

1. What would you negotiate first, and why?

I would negotiate the 401k match first, since it is the biggest unknown in the whole package and it compounds over decades. Even a small difference in match rate, like two or three percentage points, ends up being worth thousands of dollars a year that base salary alone cannot make up for. Right after that, I would ask them to clarify the bonus and profit sharing structure, since a vague mention with no percentage attached is not something I can actually weigh against another offer. Both of these are easy for the company to answer and give me the real numbers I need before I even get into base salary.

2. What's your walk-away number, and what's your target ask?

My walk-away number is \$72,000 base. Below that, especially with only two weeks of PTO and an unconfirmed 401k match, the total package would not be worth relocating to Auburn for. My target ask is \$80,000 base, which sits in the upper half of the posted \$65,000 to \$85,000 range. I think that is a fair ask given the relevant project experience I would bring, and it would make them explain why an offer should land closer to the bottom of that range instead.

3. Write your opening negotiation line.

Use today's script framework. First line only — make it specific to this role.

"I am excited about this Software Engineer role and I believe I can add real value from day one. Based on my research into comparable roles in the Auburn area, I would like to talk through a base salary closer to \$80,000, along with more detail on the bonus structure and the 401k match so I can evaluate the full offer."

Before You Submit — Reality Check

Did you compare base salary only, or the full package? (It should be the full package.)

Is your opening negotiation line confident — not apologetic? Read it out loud.

Did you research a real job you'd actually apply for — or did you pick the easy one?

Due: Submit before the end of your internship. Be prepared to walk through your negotiation line out loud.